Leadership Learning Intervention

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Leadership Learning Intervention Project

Problem of Practice

Leading Well - Fostering Sustainable Leadership and Wellbeing through Relationships

Group Description

The Student Transition and Engagement Program (STEP) is a William and Mary initiative that leads orientation, supports transitions, and fosters a sense of belonging through social event programming, promoting success and retention. STEP employs student leaders in several roles, including summer and winter interns; however, these three outlined in the ensuing statements run long-term and should be intentionally equipped to lead well.

- Initiative Directors: Coordinate social events for all calls and distinctive populations, initiatives, and programs for the university community.
- Transition Coaches: Mentor new students, offering guidance through their first six weeks of welcome through various programming pieces for first-year students to get involved and adjust to the campus community.
- Orientation Area Directors: Supervise teams of orientation leaders, ensuring that new students' transition experiences are welcoming and practical.

These student leaders serve as frontline ambassadors for the STEP office and William & Mary at large. They balance mentoring, administrative duties, and academic workloads. Due to their heavy involvement and emotional investment in supporting others, many STEPS student leaders experience burnout, stress, and difficulty maintaining a sense of balance. The "Leading Well" initiative is designed to help these student leaders build the capacity for sustainable, empathetic,

and relational leadership, allowing them to support others effectively without sacrificing their own well-being.

Problem of Practice

Burnout among STEP student leaders manifests as emotional exhaustion, reduced motivation, and disengagement. Many STEP leaders overextend themselves due to high expectations, a tendency to return to roles, and a strong desire to serve others. This burnout undermines both their personal well-being and their ability to lead effectively. By applying Relational Leadership Theory, this intervention will help student leaders reconnect with their purpose, empower one another, and adopt inclusive, process-oriented habits that sustain wellbeing over time.

Student Learning Outcomes (SLOs)

- As a result of participating in the program, STEP student leaders will demonstrate the ability to identify at least three personal signs of burnout and imbalance within their leadership and peer-support roles.
- STEP student leaders will demonstrate understanding and application of the five components of the Relational Leadership Model (RLM) by integrating principles of balance, collaboration, and well-being into leadership scenarios and activities.
- STEP student leaders will demonstrate commitment to sustainable leadership by developing and articulating at least two relational leadership practices, such as boundary-setting and reflection.

Justification for the Selected Format

The intervention consists of three 90-minute interactive sessions to be integrated into STEP's existing leadership development calendar. This concise but consistent structure allows students to:

- Engage meaningfully without overloading their schedules.
- Reflect between sessions and apply learning in real time.
- Build a small, supportive peer learning community.

The three-session format mirrors the process-oriented principles of the RLM, emphasizing that leadership development happens over time and through relationships, not in isolated, one-time workshops.

Theoretical Framework (The Relational Leadership Model)

As Guthrie, Bertrand Jones, Osteen, and Hu (2013) assert, leadership is socially constructed and therefore holds different meanings to different people. However, a growing consensus exists around effective practices (Guthrie & Jenkins, 2018). Members of this growing consensus believe that leadership is a combination of knowledge, skills, and traits. Abilities and behaviors of individuals who engage in the leadership process (Northouse, 2009)

These abilities and behaviors are central to understanding leadership as a dynamic process, which forms the foundation for the Relational Leadership Model (RLM) (Komives et al., 2013). The model defines leadership as a relational and ethical process in which people work together toward a shared purpose. It consists of five interdependent elements:

Purpose: Commits to goals through collaborative approaches that identify common ground and a shared vision that can be clearly communicated to motivate collective action.

Inclusive: Engages the complexity of diverse perspectives, experiences, and social identities with a desire to understand, a goal to expand equity, an emphasis on empathy and mutual development, a focus on connectedness, and a willingness to involve external stakeholders.

Empowering: Operates at the individual level through claiming the legitimacy of one's involvement, encouraging others to do the same, actively working to lessen barriers to involvement, and developing a complex understanding of power dynamics. Operates simultaneously at the environmental level by fostering the above along with a learning environment that cultivates trust.

Ethical: Emphasizes ethical and moral values that serve as group standards to guide decision making and behaviors as well as model these for others.

Process-Oriented: Capitalizes on relational synergy to construct an intentional process for creating the group, developing and maintaining cohesion, and acting collaboratively to achieve mission-driven goals. Includes conscious recognition of group functioning that engages in continuous meaning-making about experiences.

The Relational Leadership Model (RLM) is ideal for addressing burnout because it shifts leadership from doing to being, centering relationships, community, and wellbeing. It encourages student leaders to reconnect with their purpose, reducing emotional fatigue by aligning their efforts with personal meaning.

The inclusive element promotes collaboration and help-seeking behaviors, countering the isolation that often contributes to burnout. Through empowerment, leaders learn to share

responsibility and foster mutual support, reducing the tendency to over-function or take on too much on their own. The ethical component reframes self-care as a moral responsibility, recognizing that leaders cannot effectively serve others without caring for themselves.

The model's process-oriented nature emphasizes ongoing reflection, adaptability, and balance in leadership practice. In all, these principles provide both a philosophical foundation and a practical guide for fostering healthy, sustainable leadership within the STEP program.

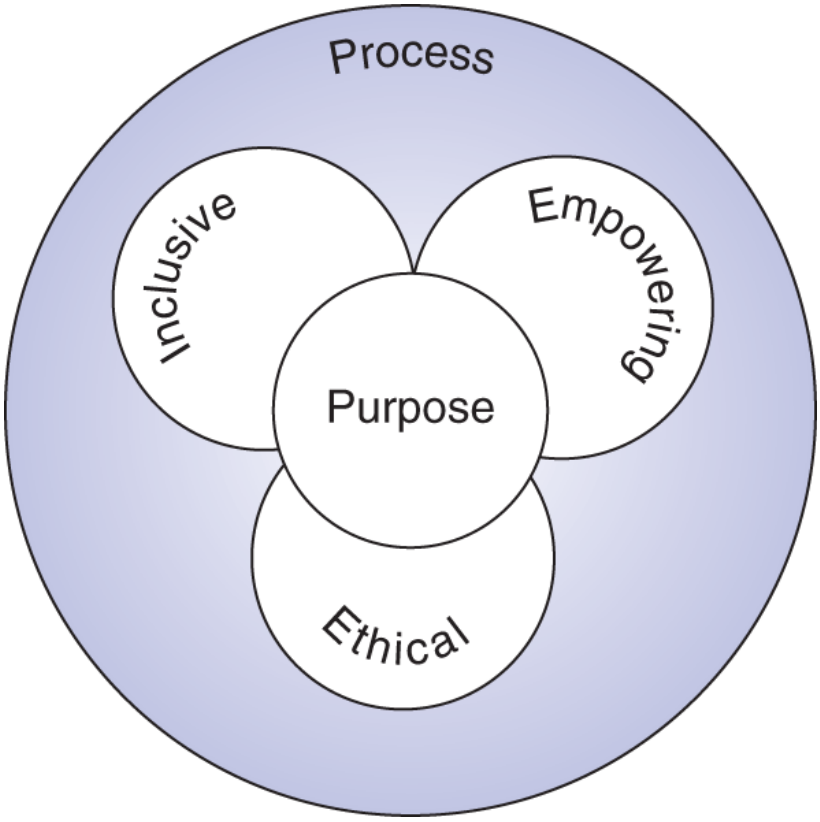

Figure 1: Relational Theory from Dugan, 2024

Program Schedule and Timeline

Session	Focus	Key Goals	Time
Session 1: Recognizing Burnout & Understanding Relational Leadership	Define burnout; explore RLM as a wellness framework	Identify personal stress signals; connect leadership and wellbeing	90 min
Session 2: Empathy, Empowerment, and Boundaries in Leadership	Learn how inclusion and empowerment reduce burnout	Practice empathy and boundary-setting as tools for sustainability	90 min
Session 3: Leading with Purpose and Process	Integrate RLM principles into daily leadership	Create a personal Relational Wellness Action Plan.	90 min

Learning Strategies and Pedagogies

The experiential learning approach will enable participants to engage actively in the learning process through interactive exercises, such as mapping burnout triggers. Cocurricular elements often coordinated and offered by student affairs departments are non–credit–bearing experiences that address leadership training, education, and development outside of the traditional classroom environment.

CAS (2009) standards stress that these learning experiences should emphasize active learning. These experiences range from workshops and service opportunities to capstone projects and portfolios; these elements are key components in students' leadership learning (Zimmerma-Oster & Burkhardt, 1999). These experiences help student leaders connect theory to practice, reinforcing that empathy and relational leadership are best developed through action, reflection, and feedback.

Reflective dialogue is another key strategy that uses guided journaling and partner sharing to deepen self-awareness and emotional intelligence. “Regardless of one’s preferred model, emotional intelligence is about being aware of one’s own emotions and those of others and being able to regulate them (Allen et al., 2016). In our own work, we identify these capacities as emotional self-perception, emotional self-control, displaying empathy, and inspiring others (Shankman et al., 2015). Humanistic programming focuses on topics such as motivations, emotion, values, identity, and personal growth, the inner work of a leader” (Allen et al., 2016, p. 81).

These experiences take place in the classroom at times, but are more often present in co-curricular programming associated with student affairs. By reflecting on their experiences and discussing insights with peers, participants strengthen their ethical grounding and embrace the process-oriented nature of the Relational Leadership Model.

Collaborative learning fosters inclusion and empowerment by encouraging peer discussions, group problem-solving, and shared debriefs. This approach models the very principles of relational leadership, valuing each voice and promoting mutual growth.

Lipman-Blumen’s relational (collaborative) set emphasizes that group process and synergy serve as motivating factors, preference for working in groups and teams in which interactions stimulate individuals to their best efforts, shares ownership of successes with others while also acknowledging personal role when things do not go well, invests in interpersonal bonds characterized by trust and reciprocity, and uses group dynamics to engage with and resolve conflict (Lipman-Blumen, 1996; Lipman-Blumen, 2000).

This strategy is supported by course readings that emphasize the importance of political skill, defined as the ability to navigate interpersonal dynamics effectively and leverage them to

achieve desired goals. Brouer et al. (2009) found that political skill could be used to compensate for dissimilarities in values, attitudes, and personality between the leader and subordinate that might otherwise reduce the quality of exchanges.

Similarly, Epitropaki et al. (2016) found that individuals in environments with a strong differentiation between high- and low-quality exchange groupings could use political skills to increase the quality of relationships with leaders above and beyond that achieved by peers. Collaborative learning gives student leaders repeated opportunities to practice these political skills in real time. Working with peers helps participants learn how to build relationships, navigate differences, and engage productively within group dynamics.

Researchers in relational leadership broadly agree that storytelling and dialogue play a central role in fostering relational processes within leadership practice(Fairhurst 2007; Fairhurst and Connaughton 2014; Henry and Wolfgramm 2018; Hosking 2007, 2011; McCauley and Palus 2021; Uhl-Bien 2006; Uhl-Bien and Ospina 2012).

Storytelling and dialogue provide the platform for examining assumptions in knowledge construction but also the dynamic tensions that exist in relational leadership, whether these are related to seemingly contradictory concepts.

Storytelling invites student leaders to share personal leadership experiences and lessons learned. This strategy builds connection and vulnerability within the group, both of which are essential to cultivating empathy, authenticity, and a strong sense of community.

Connection Across Framework, Learning Outcomes, Format, and Pedagogy

The purposeful component of the Relational Leadership Model aligns closely with Learning Outcomes 1 and 3, emphasizing reflection and storytelling as tools to help student leaders

reconnect with their values and meaning in their roles. This focus is most evident in Session 1, where participants reflect on their motivations and explore how purpose can protect against burnout. As Mumin and Dugan (2011) indicate, the philosophical shift toward creating inclusive leadership programs entails a purposeful redesign of our methods.

Acknowledging the presence of inequitable systems within higher education is an essential starting point for transformative leadership and practice change (Shields, 2010). While conversations around social justice have broadened, meaningful equity has yet to be realized (Bensimon, 2018). As a result, the development of inclusive leadership programs requires intentional and reflective design that centers participants' values, needs, and lived experiences

The inclusive component connects to Learning Outcomes 2 and 3, encouraging collaborative learning and peer dialogue through group discussion experiences. In Session 2, participants build empathy through exercises that value diverse perspectives and create space for shared experiences.

The empowering element also supports Learning Outcomes 2 and 3 through activities such as role-play and group sharing, which teach leaders how to set healthy boundaries and support one another. Sessions 2 and 3 both reinforce empowerment as a means of fostering sustainable leadership and mutual well-being.

The ethical component ties to Learning Outcome 2 and is emphasized through guided journaling and reflection. These activities model integrity and care, reminding participants that tending to their own well-being is an ethical aspect of effective leadership.

The process-oriented component aligns with all three learning outcomes, using experiential learning and structured debriefs throughout the sessions. The three-session format itself models

process-oriented growth, allowing participants to learn, apply, and reflect over time, mirroring how relational leadership develops through continuous experience and connection.

Assessment and Sustainability

Assessment Tools

- Pre & Post Reflection Cards: Self-rated burnout levels and connection to purpose.
- Facilitator Observation: Notes on engagement and application of RLM.
- Relational Wellness Action Plan: Final written reflection summarizing commitments.

Sustainability Plan

- Integrate the series into STEP's semester training cycle.
- Encourage returning leaders to co-facilitate future sessions using a peer-mentorship model.
- Adapt activities for mid-semester check-ins.

Lesson Plans

Session 1: Recognizing Burnout & the Relational Leadership Model (90 minutes)

Learning Objectives

- Identify personal signs of stress and burnout.
- Connect burnout prevention to the relational leadership principles.

Agenda (90 minutes)

1. Welcome & Relational Check-In (10 min)

   Grounding activity: One word to describe how you are arriving today.

2. Burnout 101 (15 min)

   - Emotional, cognitive, and physical signs.
   - Why are student leaders especially vulnerable?

3. Overview of RLM (15 min)

   Introduce the five elements and their connection to well-being.

4. Core Activity: Burnout Map (25 min)

   - Students map leadership tasks, stress triggers, and energy drains.
   - Small groups identify patterns and support strategies.

5. Group Reflection (15 min)

   Prompt: Which RLM component could most help you restore balance right now, and why?

6. Closing Reflection and Journaling (10 min)

   Journal prompt: What is one small relational leadership practice I want to try this week?

Session 2:

Empathy, Empowerment, and Boundaries (90 minutes)

Learning Objectives

- Explore empathy as a leadership practice.
- Practice setting healthy boundaries to support sustainability.

Agenda (90 minutes)

1. Opening Discussion (10 min)

   Prompt: What makes saying **no** hard for student leaders?

2. Empowering and Over-functioning (15 min)
   - When helping becomes over-helping
   - Relationship between empowerment and burnout

3. Mini-Workshop: Empathy in Relational Leadership (10 min)
   - Cognitive and affective empathy
   - Empathy without overextension

4. Core Activity: Role-Play Scenarios (30 min)
   - Boundary-setting with peers
   - Delegation and empowerment
   - Saying **no** while keeping relationships intact

5. Group Debrief (15 min)
   - What worked?
   - What felt uncomfortable?
   - How did boundaries empower others?

6. Closing Commitment (10 min)

   Participants write one “Empowered Boundary Commitment” for the week.

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